

HOODED PITCHER PLANT

Sarracenia minor

This insectivorous plant is highly adapted to living in nutrient-poor, acidic swamps and bogs, digesting insects to obtain phosphorus and nitrogen from their bodies. Insects are attracted by nectar into the pitcher, the long, thin, tubular, modified leaf from which the plant gets its name. The interior of the pitcher is covered in a slippery pitcher is covered in a slippery waxy coating and downward-pointing hairs that become coarser nearer the bottom of the tube. The insects fall in and, unable to get out, eventually die from exhaustion. Digestive glands in the tube walls exude enzymes which break down the insects, resulting in a liquid slurry which is then absorbed into the leaf, providing the pitcher plant with valuable nutrients.



FLOWER ∨
The flowers have five sepals, five yellow petals (which redden as they mature), and a whitish, umbrella-like style. They hang upside down.



SEED CAPSULE ∨
The broad, rough capsules crack open and scatter many tiny knobby seeds, which are about 3 mm (1/8 in) long.



RHIZOME ∨
The plant's domed pitchers rise up from a horizontally branching, underground stem known as a rhizome.



ROOTS >
The fibrous roots are 20–30 cm (8–12 in) long and grow along the length of the rhizome.



SIZE Up to 30 cm (12 in) tall
HABITAT Swampy areas in pinewoods and savannas
DISTRIBUTION S.E. USA
LEAF TYPE Hooded, narrow, funnel-shaped "pitcher"

INSECT TRAP ∨
Insects caught in the pitcher find it very difficult to escape. The leaf digests the soft parts, but the skeletons remain.



"WINDOWS" ∨
Insects fly towards the bright translucent "windows" or areoles on the upper part of the pitcher, but then slide down into the tube.

